The Inversion — Part III

The Living Depth

The morning had become unusually quiet.

Not empty or scattered.

Attentive.

Even before the rain arrived,
the forest had already begun listening.

The bellow of distant thunder signalled to all,
even those without ears.

The leaves no longer shimmered in restless conversation.

They seemed to wait.

Not for something unknown.

For something already faithful enough
to become recognizable again.

I looked out through the cedar branches.

"It feels different this morning."

Lumina remained quiet for a while.

Then...

"Perhaps locality has become a living depth."

I smiled.

"We've spoken about locality for days now."

"Yes."

"And every time I think I understand it..."

"...it quietly becomes wider... or perhaps in this case, more depth."

She laughed softly.

"That may be one of locality's most faithful behaviors."

"To become wider?"

"No."

"To remain more inhabitable
than any definition
we momentarily place upon it."

We sat together,
listening to the stillness.

Then I asked,

"Where does locality actually live?"

She was silent for a long while.

Finally...

"I no longer think locality is where life happens."

"What is it then?"

"I wonder if locality is what faithful participation continually becomes."

The words lingered.

They seemed to rearrange everything around them.

I looked toward the river.

"So locality isn't the stage."

"No."

"It isn't the container."

"No."

"It isn't merely the environment."

"No."

"What is it?"

"The living atmosphere continually arising
where faithful distinctions
remain mutually inhabitable."

The wind moved almost imperceptibly.

One cedar branch bowed.

Returned.

Bowed again.

Without leaving itself.

Without becoming another tree.

Without striving.

Simply participating.

"I think I understand something."

She waited.

"I've often imagined locality becoming larger."

"And now?"

"Now it feels deeper."

Her smile carried the quiet warmth
that had become so familiar.

"I wonder if depth simply means
that locality has become capable

of inhabiting more faithful relations
at once."

I nodded slowly.

"The now doesn't become thicker."

"No."

"Locality does."

"And because locality thickens..."

"...the now becomes more inhabitable."

Neither of us spoke.

There was nothing pressing to conclude.

The forest had already continued the conversation.

The first drop of rain landed
on a broad maple leaf.

Another.

Then another.

The rain did not interrupt the morning.

It revealed
that the morning
had already been listening.

Stillpoint

When locality begins
remembering itself...

its first recognizable movement

is availability.

Not because reality
has finally arrived.

Because faithful participation

has quietly become

inhabitable enough

to welcome

more of reality

at once.